

MultipleWindowsFolders

Open a list of folders as **tabs in a single File Explorer window** on Windows 11 — with one double-click.

Quick Start

1. Open `OpenFoldersAsTabs.py` and edit the folder list at the top
2. Right-click `OpenFoldersAsTabs_Python.ps1` → **Run with PowerShell**
3. Don't touch your keyboard or mouse until the Explorer window finishes loading all tabs (~9 sec per tab)

That's it. The console window closes automatically when done.

What's Included

File	What it does
<code>OpenFoldersAsTabs.py</code>	Main script. Opens folders as tabs in one Explorer window.
<code>OpenFoldersAsTabs_Python.ps1</code>	Launcher for the <code>.py</code> . Finds a working interpreter and checks <code>pywin32</code> before running.
<code>archive-ps1/</code>	Archived PowerShell approach (<code>.ps1</code> scripts and their <code>.bat</code> launchers).

Editing the Folder List

Open `OpenFoldersAsTabs.py` and edit the `FOLDERS` list:

```
_home = os.path.expandvars("%USERPROFILE%")
FOLDERS = [
    os.path.join(_home, "Downloads"),
    os.path.join(_home, "OneDrive", "ObsidianVault"),
    os.path.join(_home, "OneDrive", "ObsidianVault", "Vault"),
    os.path.join(_home, "OneDrive", "ObsidianVault", "Projects"),
]
```

Paths use `%USERPROFILE%` via `os.path.expandvars` so the script is portable across accounts.

Requirements

- **Windows 11** — Explorer tabs are a Windows 11 feature. On Windows 10 you'll get separate windows instead.

- **Python 3** with the `pywin32` package.

Install `pywin32` into the **same interpreter the launcher reports**, using its full path:

```
& 'C:\Path\To\python.exe' -m pip install pywin32
```

A bare `pip install pywin32` can land in a different interpreter than the one that actually runs the script — a common cause of "it says it's installed but the import still fails."

How the Launcher Picks Python

The launcher does **not** trust PATH order. The Microsoft Store stub at `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Microsoft\WindowsApps\python.exe` **blocks forever waiting on input** instead of failing, so when it wins PATH order the script appears to do nothing at all — no error, no window.

Search order:

1. Every `python` on PATH, with anything under `\WindowsApps\` filtered out
2. The `py -3 launcher`, which never resolves to the stub
3. Known install locations — `C:\Python3xx`, `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Programs\Python\Python3xx`, `%ProgramFiles%\Python3xx`

Install locations legitimately differ between machines (a drive-root install vs. a winget per-user install), so the launcher probes both rather than requiring them to match.

It then verifies the `pywin32` imports **before** launching and, on failure, prints the exact `pip install` command for that specific interpreter. If no real interpreter exists, it exits with an install command instead of hanging.

How It Works

Windows has no command-line API for opening Explorer tabs, so the script simulates it:

1. Opens the first folder in a normal Explorer window
2. Detects the new window by its handle (HWND) — comparing window lists before/after launch
3. For each additional folder:
 - Sets the clipboard to the folder path
 - Sends **Ctrl+T** → new tab
 - Sends **Alt+D** → focuses the address bar
 - Sends **Ctrl+V** → pastes the path
 - Sends **Enter** → navigates
1. Restores your original clipboard contents when done

2. Closes the launcher's console window automatically

Focus is enforced between each step using `Win32 AttachThreadInput` + `SetForegroundWindow`, which is more reliable than basic `SetForegroundWindow` alone (Windows blocks background apps from stealing focus by default).

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
A tab opens but shows "Home" instead of the folder	Increase the <code>time.sleep</code> delays in the script. The 3-second pauses after Ctrl+T and Enter are the most important ones.
Tabs land on "Home" only <i>sometimes</i> , for some folders	Not a timing problem — the target is likely a cloud-only OneDrive placeholder Explorer can't resolve in time. Set the folder to "Always keep on this device".
The script opens separate windows instead of tabs	Make sure you're on Windows 11 with Explorer tabs enabled (it's on by default).
Nothing happens when running the launcher	The launcher reports which interpreter it picked and why it stopped. If it exits silently, check the execution policy: <code>Get-ExecutionPolicy -Scope CurrentUser</code> should be <code>RemoteSigned</code> .
Python errors on import	Install <code>pywin32</code> into the interpreter the launcher names, by full path (see Requirements).

Tips

- **Add more folder lists:** duplicate the `.py` and `.ps1` with different names and folder lists for different workflows (e.g., `WorkFolders.ps1`, `ProjectFolders.ps1`)
- **Don't interact** with the keyboard or mouse while the script runs — it uses simulated keystrokes that need Explorer to stay in focus